CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 03

WEEK OF 23 NOVEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



RETAIL

Keep the shutters up.

Payment outages, cyber attacks, abuse on the shop floor, lockdowns and warm freezers. How to keep stores trading and colleagues safe when it goes wrong at peak.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

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A practical playbook for retail resilience leaders: how stores and head office work as one when tills, systems, fridges or people are under threat, with a peak trading plan for Black Friday and Christmas.

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FOREWORD

Retail crises rarely start at head office. They start at a till, a freezer or a shop door.

In April 2025 a cyber attack forced Marks and Spencer to pause online orders for 46 days, and the retailer estimated the hit to operating profit at around £300m before mitigation.[1,2] The Co-op shut down systems to contain a parallel attack, lost an estimated £206m of sales in six months and later confirmed that data on all 6.5 million members had been taken.[3,4] In October 2026 an incident at Ahold Delhaize took online grocery services offline in the Benelux and the US; the group now expects fourth-quarter sales to be €200m to €250m lower.[5]

The same month, attackers switched supermarket refrigeration into defrost from the internet. France's CERT-FR reported numerous compromised controllers, and on 2 November a second wave reached stores in Ireland, Belgium and Sweden and food suppliers in the UK.[6,7] Meanwhile, the BRC counts more than 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against retail staff every day.[8]

This playbook is for the people who have to hold it all together: resilience, security, store operations, IT and communications leaders. It sets out how a store and head office should work as one team on the worst day of the year, what to have ready before Black Friday, and the messages to send in the first hour. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three things keep a store trading on a bad day.

Retail incidents move fast and land on the shop floor first. The retailers that cope best are not the ones with the thickest manuals. They are the ones where stores and head office already know who decides, how they talk and what each store does without being asked.

One incident, one team

A store manager and the head office incident lead share the same severity scale, the same facts and the same clock. Nobody waits for a meeting to start.

Fast, two-way messages

Head office can reach every store, and every store can reach head office, in minutes, with a record of who has read what and who has not.

People before stock

Every procedure starts with colleague and customer safety, from a queue that turns hostile to a lockdown call or a freezer that cannot be trusted.

A store that cannot take payment is not trading. It just has the lights on.

The hardest retail incidents are the ones that turn an IT problem into a shop floor problem within minutes: long queues, angry customers and colleagues left to explain something nobody has told them.

PART 01

Ready for peak.

Decide now how stores and head office will work together, how you will grade an incident and what must be true before Black Friday.

01 Store and head office as one team

02 Six threats, first actions

03 A retail severity ladder

04 Peak readiness in six steps

READY FOR PEAK

One incident, two worlds: the store and head office

> **Every head office decision has a store consequence, and someone must own telling stores about it.**

A retail incident is lived in two places at once. At head office, it is a dashboard turning red, a bridge call and a decision about which systems to switch off. In the store, it is a queue that will not move, a customer who wants to know why and a manager who has heard nothing.

The 2025 attacks showed how quickly the two worlds connect. M&S first disclosed a cyber incident after problems with contactless payments and click and collect over the Easter weekend, and stopped taking online orders three days later.[2] The Co-op said it kept trading while it contained its attack, but had to deal with payment problems and empty shelves along the way.[3]

The decisions that protect the business at head office are often the ones that hurt stores most. Taking systems offline can stop an attacker. It can also stop stock files, price updates, loyalty scanners and delivery slots. When Ahold Delhaize took systems offline as a precaution in October 2026, stores stayed open but some shelf labels showed out-of-date promotional prices and loyalty scanners failed.[9]

So the first rule of retail incident management is that every head office decision has a store consequence, and someone must own telling stores about it. The second is that information must flow upwards as well as down. Store managers see the effects first: the first declined card, the first fridge alarm, the first group of shoplifters who turn aggressive. They need a fast, simple way to raise it and to know it has landed.

That means one severity scale that stores and head office both use, one place where the facts live, scheduled updates even when there is nothing new, and acknowledgement from every store so you know who has not heard. It also means trusting store managers with clear authority to act on safety without waiting for permission: to close a door, stop a queue or take stock off sale.

None of this needs to be built during an incident. It needs to be agreed, written down and rehearsed before the busiest weeks of the year.

SIX THREATS

Six retail threats and the first moves that matter

What each side does in the first five minutes, without waiting to be told.

THREAT	FIRST STORE ACTION	FIRST HEAD OFFICE ACTION
Till or payment outage	Switch to the cash and offline procedure. Stop restarting terminals. Tell customers what works.	Confirm scope. Send one instruction to all stores with the next update time.
Cyber attack on core systems	Trade on what still works. Report anything odd. Do not reset devices unless told.	Contain, keep evidence, decide what to switch off and tell stores what each shutdown means.[2,9]
Violence or abuse	Make safe, call 999 if anyone is in danger, do not pursue. Colleague first.	Check it is logged and reported, support the manager, make the next shifts safe.
Fire, threat or attack nearby	Evacuate, invacuate or lock down as briefed. Account for colleagues.	Alert nearby stores, convene the incident group, own customer and media lines.
Cold-chain failure	Probe food by hand, take unsafe stock off sale, do not just reset the controller.[6,10]	Call the contractor, find other sites with the same controllers, take them offline.
Rogue message to customers	Expect questions. Use the approved line and do not guess.	Lock the channel used, then tell customers plainly what to ignore.[11]

SEVERITY

A retail severity ladder that stores and head office share

Grade early and regrade often. If in doubt, go one level higher and step down later.

SEV 1 **Critical**	TRIGGERS Payments, tills or core systems down across many stores or online. A weapon, terror or life-safety incident at any store. Controller tampering at several sites.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Crisis team, all affected store and area managers, IT and security leads, communications and legal. `Voice · SMS · push · bridge in 15 min`
SEV 2 **Major**	TRIGGERS Outage in one region or one channel. Serious assault on a colleague. Fridge or freezer failure with stock at risk. A credible threat to a store.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Incident manager, area and regional managers, IT or facilities on call, communications on standby. `SMS · push · escalate after 10 min`
SEV 3 **Moderate**	TRIGGERS Problem at a single store: tills failing, a violent incident without injury, one fridge alarm, an evacuation for a false alarm.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Store manager, area manager, service desk or facilities helpdesk. `Push · email`
SEV 4 **Minor**	TRIGGERS Verbal abuse logged, a single device fault, a near miss or a suspicious approach to staff.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Store manager, recorded for trend reporting and weekly review. `App · email`

BEFORE BLACK FRIDAY

Peak readiness in six steps

Black Friday falls on 27 November this year. Finish these before then, and repeat the checks before the last trading weekend before Christmas.

01 Freeze change and name the on-call team

No non-essential changes to payments, tills, e-commerce or networks over peak. Publish who is on call for every day, including weekends.

02 Test the offline and cash procedure

Confirm what each till and terminal can do offline, how much cash float stores hold and who decides to go cash only.

03 Rehearse one outage and one lockdown

A 30-minute exercise with store and area managers: a payment failure at 10am on a Saturday, then a lockdown call.

04 Check every contact list

Store, area and regional managers, key suppliers, payment providers and contractors, each with a tested out-of-hours number.

05 Close the doors you forgot

List fridge controllers, building systems and supplier remote access that face the internet, and take them off it.[6,12]

06 Brief colleagues on safety

De-escalation, how to raise an alarm, when not to intervene and who to call. Staff the hotspots, not just the tills.

PART 02

When it happens.

The first hour on the worst day, and the procedures for violence, lockdown and a cold chain you cannot trust.

01 The first hour of a peak outage

02 After an assault on a colleague

03 Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

04 A cold-chain incident

05 Messages ready to send

THE FIRST HOUR

Black Friday, 07:40: card payments fail

An illustrative timeline. The cause is not yet known. Act on what you can see.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**First reports reach the service desk** Dozens of stores report card terminals declining. Online checkout errors climb.	SERVICE DESK
T+00:05	**Incident declared at SEV 1** Several regions and online are hit. The bridge opens and the log starts.	INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:10	**First instruction to every store** Go to the cash and offline procedure, stop restarting terminals, acknowledge. Next update 08:30.	RETAIL OPERATIONS
T+00:15	**Find the cause, keep the evidence** Check provider status and internal systems for intrusion. Nothing is switched off without a decision.	SECURITY LEAD
T+00:20	**Protect people, tell customers** Managers may pause entry if queues become unsafe. Banner, social posts and store announcement: open, cash accepted, next update time.	SECURITY · COMMS
T+00:45	**Decide on containment** If attack is suspected: isolate, call the response provider and insurer, assess whether personal data is involved.	SECURITY LEAD · LEGAL
T+01:00	**First update to the crisis team** Stores affected, cash position, customer impact, likely duration, decisions needed, next update.	INCIDENT MANAGER

VIOLENCE AND ABUSE

After an assault on a colleague: six steps that matter

The BRC estimates over 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against retail staff a day, 118 of them physically violent.[8]

01 Make safe and get help

Call 999 if anyone is hurt or in danger. Do not detain or follow the offender.

02 Look after the colleague

First aid, a quiet room, someone with them, a safe way home. Not back on the till.

03 Keep the evidence

Secure CCTV and body-worn video, note witnesses, write it up within the shift.

04 Report it, every time

Report to police and keep the reference. The new offence of assaulting a retail worker is enacted but not yet in force.[13]

05 Tell head office within the hour

One message, one channel: area manager, security and HR hear the same facts.

06 Follow up and learn

Call the colleague next day, review staffing and layout, share intelligence locally.

MARTYN'S LAW PROCEDURES

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 will require shops where 200 or more people can be expected at once to have these four procedures, so far as is reasonably practicable. The duties are not yet in force.[14]

Evacuation

Getting people away from danger by moving them out of the premises. Know your exits, assembly points and who sweeps each area.[14]

Invacuation

Moving people to a safer place inside, such as a stockroom or back corridor away from glass and entrances.[14]

Lockdown

Securing the premises to stop people entering or leaving. Know which doors lock, who locks them and how fast.[14]

Communication

Getting information to everyone on site: colleagues, customers and contractors, with a way to reach staff who are off the shop floor.[14]

The implementation period is at least 24 months from Royal Assent on 3 April 2025. Premises expecting 800 or more people fall into the enhanced tier, with wider duties.[14]

COLD CHAIN

When you cannot trust the fridge

Refrigeration controllers have been tampered with remotely across Europe this autumn. Treat an unexplained defrost as a possible attack until you know otherwise.

Spot it

An alarm, a case warming for no reason or a defrost cycle outside its schedule.

Check the food, not the display

Probe product temperatures by hand. In England, Wales and Northern Ireland chilled food must legally be kept at 8°C or below.[10]

Take it off sale

Remove anything you cannot show stayed at a safe temperature. Record what, where and when for the insurer and food safety team.

Cut the remote link

With the contractor, take controllers off the internet and allow access only through a secure VPN. CERT-FR warns a factory reset alone is not enough for end-of-life kit.[6]

Restore and check every site

Reconfigure, check defrost schedules, then look for the same controllers at every other store and depot.[6,12]

Check your insurance conditions before cutting data links to the refrigeration contractor, as CERT-FR advises.[6]

MESSAGES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and honest. Fill the brackets, never guess the cause, and always give the time of the next update.

SMS · STORE MANAGERS

146 chars

> SEV1: Card payments down in many stores. Switch to cash and offline procedure now. Do not restart terminals. Reply 1 when done. Next update 08:30.

Keep it under 160 characters so it arrives as one message.

PUSH · ALL STORE COLLEAGUES

> Some payment systems are down. Your safety comes first. Stay calm, use the till script, call security if anyone becomes aggressive. Please do not post about this online.

WEB BANNER · CUSTOMERS

> We're sorry: some card payments aren't working in our stores right now. Stores are open and accepting [cash]. We're working to fix it and will update here at [10:00].

Only say what you know is true. Add what still works.

EMAIL · SUPPLIERS AND HAULIERS

> We are managing an IT incident affecting [systems]. Deliveries continue as booked unless we call you. Do not act on any request to change bank details or give access. Verify on [known number].

Attackers often follow up with fake supplier requests.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA

> We are aware of an issue affecting payments in some of our stores and are working to resolve it as quickly as possible. Our stores remain open. We will share more information as soon as we can.

SMS · STORE MANAGER, COLD CHAIN

153 chars

> SEV2: Fridge controller alarm at your store. Probe food temps now. Do not reset the controller. Take unsafe stock off sale. Reply 1, then call [FM line].

PART 03

Recover and rehearse.

Three scenarios to test your plan, a dated plan with owners and the questions to put to your leadership team.

01 Three scenarios

02 This week, this month, this quarter

03 Questions and checklist

SCENARIOS

Three illustrative scenarios to rehearse before peak

GROCER, 400 STORES

Card terminals fail on the last Saturday before Christmas

THE TRIGGER

A provider outage hits two regions at 10am. Queues build and answers vary.

WHAT HURTS

Waiting for certainty before saying anything.

WHAT HELPS

One acknowledged instruction to every store within ten minutes.

REHEARSE

Run one store on cash only for 30 minutes.

CONVENIENCE CHAIN, FRANCHISE AND COMPANY STORES

Freezers defrost overnight in a dozen stores

THE TRIGGER

Opening staff find warm freezers in defrost. The common link is remote access.

WHAT HURTS

Restocking before anyone has cut remote access.

WHAT HELPS

A probe-and-quarantine routine and a list of controllers by site.

REHEARSE

Ask area managers to name their controller models.

FASHION RETAILER, FLAGSHIP STORE

An aggressive group, then a call to lock down

THE TRIGGER

A group threatens colleagues, then police advise of an incident nearby.

WHAT HURTS

A tannoy nobody hears upstairs, no list of who is on shift.

WHAT HELPS

Colleagues who know the safe room and which doors lock.

REHEARSE

A ten-minute lockdown walk-through each quarter.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure, and date every action.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Publish the peak on-call rota and change freeze. Send the severity ladder and the six message templates to every store.	Head of resilience
This week	Test the cash and offline procedure in one store per region. Confirm payment provider escalation contacts.	Retail operations director
This month	Take fridge controllers and other building systems off the internet. Review supplier remote access.	Facilities and IT security
This month	Brief every store on violence response and reporting. Check alarms, body-worn video and radios work.	Head of security
This quarter	Map stores likely to be in scope of Martyn's Law and draft the four procedures for each format.	Head of security, with legal
This quarter	Run a joint store and head office exercise on a cyber outage. Report gaps and dated fixes to the board.	Chief operating officer

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

TRADING

- ? If every card terminal failed at 10am on a Saturday, how long until every store had one clear instruction?
- ? Which head office shutdown decisions would stop stores trading, and who tells them?
- ? Do we know which store systems and fridge controllers face the internet today?

PEOPLE

- ? Is every assault on a colleague reported, followed up and visible to the board?
- ? Could each large store evacuate, invacuate or lock down today, and has it practised?
- ? How would we reach colleagues who are off shift or off the shop floor?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready for peak?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **One severity ladder used by stores and head office**
  With named owners for each level.
- [ ] **Peak on-call rota and change freeze published**
  Covering every trading day to the new year.
- [ ] **Cash and offline procedure tested this month**
  In at least one store per region.
- [ ] **Message templates approved and loaded**
  Store managers, colleagues, customers, suppliers and media.
- [ ] **Fridge controllers and building systems off the internet**
  Remote access only through a secure route.
- [ ] **Every assault reported and followed up**
  With aftercare for the colleague and a store risk review.
- [ ] **Evacuation, invacuation and lockdown briefed**
  And walked through in large stores.
- [ ] **Every store acknowledges alerts**
  And non-responders are chased automatically.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Severity level
A shared grade (SEV 1 to SEV 4) that sets who is alerted, how fast and how often.

Offline payment mode
A terminal setting that stores some card transactions for later authorisation when the network is down.

Change freeze
A period, usually over peak, when only essential changes to systems are allowed.

Invacuation
Moving people to a safer place inside a building, away from danger outside.

Lockdown
Securing a building so people cannot enter or leave until it is safe.

Martyn's Law
The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, which sets duties for larger public premises.

Cold chain
Keeping chilled and frozen food at safe temperatures from supplier to shelf.

Refrigeration controller
A device that runs fridges and freezers and can often be managed remotely.

Defrost cycle
A scheduled warm-up that clears ice. Stretched or repeated, it spoils stock.

Acknowledgement
A recipient's confirmation that an alert has been read and acted on.

Incident manager
The person who runs the response, keeps the log and sets the rhythm of updates.

Holding line
A short, accurate statement used while facts are still being established.

Body-worn video
A camera worn by colleagues or security staff that records incidents as evidence.

Responsible person
Under Martyn's Law, the person or organisation in control of qualifying premises.

Remote access
A route for suppliers or engineers to manage systems from outside the store.

End of life
When a manufacturer stops issuing security fixes for a product.

PLATFORM

Where Crises Control fits in a retail incident

How the steps in this playbook map to Crises Control modules.

Send the first instruction to every store manager and see who has acknowledged, with automatic escalation to area managers.	**Ping** Mass alerting by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgement tracking and escalation on no response.
Run the incident from one workspace with one log, shared by stores, head office and suppliers.	**Incident Manager** A workspace per incident: team coordination, a single communication log and message templates.
Turn the cash procedure, cold-chain checks and lockdown steps into tasks with owners and deadlines.	**Task Manager** Digitised procedures: tasks assigned with owners, deadlines and escalation paths.
See which stores are affected, what has been done and where escalations are waiting.	**Control Centre** A live view of tasks, communications, locations and escalations.
Give colleagues a one-touch way to raise an alarm with their location.	**SOS** One-touch mobile escalation with GPS location for frontline staff.
Keep a timestamped record of every message and decision for the post-incident review and insurer.	**Audit Trail** Automatic timestamps and incident timelines, ready for the post-incident report.

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Sources and notes

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Keep every store in the loop.

Crises Control helps retailers alert every store in seconds, see who has acknowledged, run incidents from one place and keep colleagues safe on the shop floor.

Request a demo | www.crises-control.com

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READ THE COMPANION REPORT

Intelligence report No. 03 · When the tills go dark